Van Nuys - Ground is broken for East Valley light rail line - Last similar transit project in the area was built more than 20 years ago

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A passel of local, regional, state and federal officials, led by outgoing Los Angeles Mayor Eric Garcetti, launched the long-awaited groundbreaking in Van Nuys for the East San Fernando Valley light rail transit project, years in the planning. They praised the first rail project to get underway in the San Fernando Valley since the Red Line subway was built to North Hollywood — more than two decades ago.

Perhaps the most earnest of those who lined up to celebrate a new transit line for the bustling Valley was Panorama City Neighborhood Council board member Tony Wilkinson, a longtime voice urging more transit for the Valley. Wilkinson noted that residents engaged in “a decadeslong fight” for the East Valley line, which will be completed between 2028 and 2030.

In 2020, the Red Line opened in NoHo and fundamentally changed that once low-key Valley community. Since then the Valley has grown from a population of 1.69 million to 1.86

million, and if it were a city it would be the fifth largest in the U.S.

Among those applauding Friday’s groundbreaking were L.A. City Council President and Metro board member Paul Krekorian, L.A. City Councilmember Monica Rodriguez, Valley-area Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, Metro CEO Stephanie Wiggins, Metro board Chairman Ara Najarian, federal transit official Charlene Lee-Lorenzo and Wilkinson.

This week, Krekorian said that of the roughly 100 rail stations in L.A. County, only two are in the San Fernando Valley. “The San Fernando Valley has long felt left behind by this agency,” he said of Metro.

When built, the new line will start at the Van Nuys Metrolink station, run 5 miles northward on the Van Nuys Boulevard median and then 2 1/2 miles on San Fernando Road, finally reaching the Sylmar/San Fernando Metrolink station.

Metro’s board will submit an application next week to the California State Transportation Agency with an expectation that the agency will allot significant funds to help build the new line. Metro is asking the state for $600 million. The groundbreaking on Friday launched the initial utility work on the first segment of the line.

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